Rangarajan have kept me on my intellectual toes. Srinath Raghavan's move to Chennai has meant proximity to a friend and historian.

Pazha. Athiyaman, B. Mathivanan and Y. Manikandan have been comrades in arms for longer than I can remember.

The writing of this book was punctuated by four surgical procedures. I am grateful to the medical experts M.A. Muthusethupathy, S. Mohan Raj, J. Amalorpavanathan, V.K. Menon and A.B. Gopalamurugan for their skilled treatment and care. In a moment of medical crisis when teaching at the University of Chicago in the spring of 2023, Neeraj Jolly's medical intervention, and the moral support of Whitney Cox, Dipesh Chakraborty and Rochona Mazumdar were crucial.

Uttara Vijay provided excellent research assistance in the summer of 2022. Raghunath Nageswaran provided timely help by checking some references at the last moment.

Kanakalatha Mukund not only read the first draft but also saved me from the more egregious errors of grammar and style. To Sunil Khilnani I owe the title of this book. Aditya Balasubramanian, who has helped me with resources on innumerable occasions, carefully read the manuscript and alerted me to the pitfalls of nationalist hagiography. Gopalkrishna Gandhi's meticulous reading of the text and warm endorsement means much to me. Ramachandra Guha read the final draft carefully, commented enthusiastically, commended it generously and embellished the text with his editorial tweaks.

Manasi Subramaniam took on this book with great enthusiasm, provided excellent editorial advice and has generally run a tight ship. Saba Nehal has copy-edited the manuscript with care. S. Thillainayagam and Yash Daiv helped with the final proofs and Amit Prasad prepared the preliminary index.

A project such as this can take a heavy toll on one's family. It is the patience and love of Anitha and Kannal that has sustained me over the years.

Chalapathy